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– Billy Joel

Not only is it interesting to look at popular music from the point of view of musicians aspiring to create the next hit single. Indeed, it is also interesting to analyse recent music since music is an essential part of any culture. By analysing popular music one can learn about what the current culture is, how it changed and how it varied. In the following, we'll look at the most popular music of the last two decades [1] to answer which musical and lyrical elements we can identify and analyse the change of them.

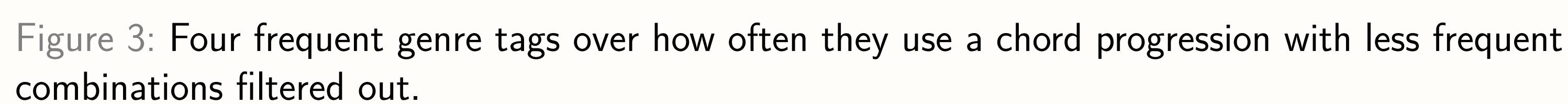
The most used harmonic progression (I, VI, III, VII) can for example be played in B-minor with chords Bm, G, D, A, like in Ed Sheeran's "Shivers".



Musicians often write songs in the same key they can sing in and therefore use the same chords more often. Most chords in figure 2 can be played in C-major or A-minor. We can also see that A-minor key is more popular than C-major key, since D and Em work better in A-minor compared to C-major.¹



It shouldn't be surprising, that the most frequent genre in popular music is *pop*-music. Looking at the top tags of the song we got from the *LastFM API* [3] and comparing to the identified harmonic progressions, we can see which genres use mainly which chord progressions, see figure 3. Here we can identify, how pop dominates in more complex progressions compared to rap and hip-hop.



¹D and Em are roughly the IV and V of A-minor, but the II and III of C-major, which are less important harmonics, as you can see in figure 1.

Song lyrics often reflect emotions and moods of their time. By extracting them from *Genius API* [2] and analyzing their polarity over the years with *TextBlob* [6], we can identify cultural trends about how the language in songs had become positively or negatively charged, see figure 4.



In addition to polarity, the most frequently used words in song lyrics provide insight into lyrical trends. Figure 5 displays the most common words appearing in lyrics over the years.



The duration of songs has evolved over time, reflecting changes in listening habits and industry standards. We received the duration of songs with *Spotify API* [5]. Even though minimal, we can see a small general trend to shorter songs in figure 6 – a length of 3 minutes and 30 seconds seems ideal.



Tempo plays a crucial role in defining the energy and feel of a song. We used *SongBPM* [4] to find the beats per minute of the songs. In figure 7 we can see how it changed and how variant it is.



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